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Ministry Resources Hub

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Lesson 7. Bible Study Methods

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Lesson 7. Bible Study Methods

I. HOW TO APPROACH THE BIBLE

A. The Bible is Inspired by God

1. **Definition of Inspiration:** The Bible is not just a collection of human writings; it is inspired by God. In 2 Timothy 3:16, Paul writes that all Scripture is “God-breathed.” This means that God guided the authors through the Holy Spirit to write His words for us.
2. **Authority of Scripture:** Because the Bible is God-breathed, it carries His authority. When we read Scripture, we are not just reading words of ancient wisdom—we are reading God’s direct communication to humanity.
3. **Impact of Scripture:** God’s Word is living and active (Hebrews 4:12). It not only teaches and informs but also transforms our hearts and minds.

II. THE TIMELESSNESS OF THE BIBLE

- A. **Relevant Across Generations:** The Bible was written over a span of 1,500 years, by over 40 different authors, in different cultural and historical contexts. Despite this diversity, it presents a unified message that transcends time and culture. Its teachings are applicable to every person in every era.
- B. **Scripture as a Mirror:** James 1:23-25 describes Scripture as a mirror that shows us our true selves. As we read it, we see areas of our lives that need transformation, and we receive the power to change through God’s help.
- C. **Timeless Promises:** Many of God’s promises in the Bible apply to us today. When we approach the Bible, we can hold onto these promises, knowing that God’s Word never fails (Isaiah 40:8).

III. PERSONAL CONNECTION WITH GOD THROUGH SCRIPTURE

- A. **God’s Letter to Us:** The Bible is more than just a book of laws or moral guidelines—it is God’s personal letter to us. It reveals His love, His character, and His desire for a relationship with each of us.
- B. **Hearing God Speak:** In John 10:27, Jesus says, “My sheep hear my voice; I know them, and they follow me.” One of the primary ways we hear God’s voice is

through the Bible. As we read His Word, we learn to recognize His voice and follow His leading.

- C. **Knowing God's Heart:** Each book of the Bible reveals different aspects of God's character. In the Psalms, we see His compassion and care. In the Gospels, we see His humility and love through Jesus. In Revelation, we see His power and majesty. To truly know God, we must immerse ourselves in His Word.

IV. STEPS FOR STUDYING THE BIBLE (INDUCTIVE METHOD)

A. Step 1: Pray for Guidance

1. Begin by acknowledging that the Holy Spirit is the author of Scripture, and ask Him to teach and guide you.
2. Before opening your Bible, ask God to help you understand what you're about to read. Pray for insight, clarity, and the guidance of the Holy Spirit. In John 16:13, Jesus says that the Holy Spirit will guide us into all truth.

B. Step 2: Observation

1. **Read:** You study the scriptures as a diligent student (2 Timothy 2:15). As you study, you read thoughtfully and meditatively (Psalm 1:2). This is where you: Think it over, think it out, think it through, and write it out.
2. **Ask:** "What does the passage say?" Look for key phrases, repetition, characters, settings, and relationships. Look for the who, what, when, where, how, and why of the passage.
3. **Exercise:** Take a short passage, like John 15:1-8. Identify repeated words such as "abide," "fruit," and "vine."

A. Step 3: Interpretation

1. **Ask:** "What does this mean?" Consider the historical and cultural context. For instance, what was the significance of a vine in Jesus' time?
2. **Tools for Interpretation:** You may not have access to a study Bible, commentaries, or Bible dictionaries. Remember these truths and consult trusted sources and mentors if you're wrestling with an interpretation. (Psalm 119:33-40, 2 Timothy 3:16-17)
 - a. Read the text and lift out the truths that are there.
 - b. Do not bring ideas, thoughts, or opinions and put them into the text.

- c. The law of context rules – Always read what comes before and after.
- d. Scripture interprets Scripture. Read the Bible over and over, and you will find that Scripture itself gives the meaning of a text. Seek the full counsel of the word of God.
- e. Scripture will not contradict scripture.
- f. Interpret scripture literally. It usually means what it says so look for the clear meaning.

D. **Step 4: Application**

1. **Ask:** “How does this apply to me?” Write down specific actions, attitudes, or changes that need to be implemented.
2. **Exercise:** From John 15, write down how you can “abide in Christ” in your daily life—such as setting aside time for prayer, obeying His commands, and practicing gratitude.

E. Twelve Application Questions about the text: 2 Tim 3:16-17

1. Is there an attitude to adjust?
2. Is there a promise to claim?
3. Is there a priority to change?
4. Is there a lesson to learn?
5. Is there an issue to resolve?
6. Is there a command to obey?
7. Is there an activity to avoid?
8. Is there a truth to believe?
9. Is there an idol to tear down?
0. Is there an offense to forgive?
1. Is there a new direction to take?
2. Is there a sin to confess?

V. **GROUP STUDY PRACTICE**

- A. **Group Activity:** Form groups of 3-4, choose a passage (e.g., Luke 10:25-37, the Parable of the Good Samaritan), and go through observation, interpretation, and application together.

B. **Facilitator's Role:** The facilitator should ensure everyone contributes to the discussion, helping participants see how the Word applies to their lives.

This lesson was provided by Joshua Nations (JoshuaNations.org).

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